

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 3 — “The First Subject”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone ash.

Approx. 18 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top)

The Wastes. A jagged landscape of broken stone and swirling mist where geometry has no meaning. The two gates are now thin silver needles on the far horizon — barely visible. EGRIS walks alone across cracked ground, boots crunching on calcified ruins.

SFX: `krch... krch...`

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow horizontal, center — detail of the ground)

Close on Egris’s boot crushing something white and brittle — not quite bone, not quite stone. Fragments scatter.

SFX: `krnch`

Panel 3 (wide, bottom)

Pull back. EGRIS, a lone figure walking into pale mist and broken towers that lean at impossible angles. The wind is visible — heavy, pushing him rather than blowing past.

NARRATION (box): The wind in the Wastes did not blow. It pushed. A heavy, stagnant pressure that tasted of cold ash and forgotten names.

PAGE 2

Panels: 4

Panel 1 (wide)

A VOICE from off-panel, thin and fragile like tearing parchment.

VOICE (off-panel): “You are going the wrong way, Great Egris.”

Panel 2

EGRIS stops mid-stride. His hand drifts instinctively to his empty hip — the place where a weapon should be. He turns his head slightly, not all the way.

No dialogue.

Panel 3 (wide, the reveal)

A MAN follows exactly ten paces behind. He is thin, stooped, wearing tattered silk robes of a court official. His fingers are stained permanently black with ink. A heavy wooden satchel hangs across his

chest, rattling as he walks.

SFX (from the satchel): chnk chnk

Panel 4

Close on the man's face — cracked spectacles, wide nervous eyes, sweat despite the cold.

No dialogue.

PAGE 3

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

EGRIS, not fully turning, speaks flatly.

EGRIS: "There is no 'way' here. Therefore, there is no wrong one."

Panel 2

The SCRIBE struggles to keep pace, clutching his satchel to his chest.

SCRIBE: "There is the way of the many, and the way of the fool."

SCRIBE: "The many stay near the gates, hoping for a stray crumb of grace or a familiar face. The fools walk into the Wastes to be eaten by the Hollow."

Panel 3 (tight)

SCRIBE: "You appear to be the latter."

PAGE 4

Panels: 4

Panel 1 (large)

EGRIS stops completely and turns to face the scribe. The man FLINCHES — a full-body recoil — but he does not run.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Close on EGRIS's eyes — calm, reading him.

EGRIS: "You knew me."

Panel 3 (large)

The SCRIBE looks up through cracked spectacles, trembling but holding his ground.

SCRIBE: "I spent twenty-two years in a stone room in Samarkand recording your tax decrees and your execution lists."

Panel 4

SCRIBE (bitter edge creeping in): "I know the shape of your signature better than I know the face of my own mother."

PAGE 5

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The SCRIBE steadies himself — a man who has decided to finish what he started.

SCRIBE: "My name was Arghun. I was a scribe of the empire you burned."

Panel 2

EGRIS, still unreadable.

EGRIS: "And now?"

Panel 3 (wide, ARGHUN clutching his satchel tighter)

ARGHUN: "Now I am a dead man in a place where even stories die."

PAGE 6**Panels: 3****Panel 1** (large)

ARGHUN gestures outward at the broken landscape.

ARGHUN: "The Wastes eat memory, Great Egris. Every hour you spend out here, a piece of who you were flakes away."

Panel 2 (tight, desperate)

ARGHUN: "Your first victory. The name of your first horse. The color of your wife's eyes..."

ARGHUN: "The Gray takes it all until you are just another shadow screaming at the wind."

Panel 3

EGRIS, quiet.

EGRIS: "If you know this, why are you following me into the dark?"

PAGE 7**Panels: 3****Panel 1** (large)

ARGHUN looks out at the jagged horizon — broken towers, mist, emptiness. Then back at Egris.

ARGHUN: "Because I have spent my life writing about kings who were afraid of their own shadows."

Panel 2

ARGHUN (softer, exhausted): "You just walked away from God and the Devil without looking back."

Panel 3 (tight on Arghun's ink-stained hands)

ARGHUN: "If anyone can hold onto their name in this place, it is the man who made the world fear it."

PAGE 8**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top — the gesture)

ARGHUN sinks to his knees — not in worship, but out of sheer exhaustion. His satchel thuds onto the ground beside him.

SFX: thud

ARGHUN: “If you are building a kingdom of nothing, you will need someone to write the laws.”

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

ARGHUN, kneeling, looking up at the standing Egris.

ARGHUN: “Even a ghost needs to know what is forbidden.”

PAGE 9

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

EGRIS reaches down and grips ARGHUN’s shoulder — firm, economical. He hauls the scribe to his feet in one motion.

SFX: grip

Panel 2

The two men standing now, face-to-face. Egris still gripping his shoulder.

EGRIS: “I am not building a kingdom of laws.”

Panel 3 (wide, both turning toward the mist ahead)

EGRIS: “I am building a nation of the chosen.”

PAGE 10

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS releases Arghun and begins walking again. Arghun adjusts his satchel, steadying himself.

EGRIS (over shoulder): “Walk, Arghun. Your ink is dry, but your mind is still sharp.”

Panel 2

The two men walking side-by-side now — no longer pursuer and pursued. The mist curls around their legs.

EGRIS (continuing): “We will see what the Gray can take from us.”

Panel 3 (tight on Arghun’s worried face)

ARGHUN (whisper): “And if it takes everything?”

Panel 4 (narrow, silent beat — Egris does not look back)

No dialogue.

PAGE 11

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — closing image)

Wide shot from behind: EGRIS and ARGHUN walking together into the deep mist ahead. The broken towers loom in shadow. The pale empty sky presses down. Their footprints trail behind them in the ash — the only proof anyone has walked this way.

At the bottom corner, EGRIS's final line:
EGRIS: "Then we will find something new to be."

— END OF CHAPTER 3 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **This is a two-person chamber piece** — the whole chapter is Egris and Arghun meeting and walking together. No action, no spectacle. Let silence and posture carry the weight.
- **Arghun's design:** Thin, stooped, cracked spectacles, ink-stained fingers (always visible when his hands are on-panel), tattered court silk, heavy wooden satchel. He is nervous but not cowardly — show it in his body language (flinches but holds ground, trembles but finishes sentences).
- **The Wastes landscape:** jagged, non-Euclidean ruins, mist that moves like a living thing, ground that crunches like dry cartilage. Use heavy screentone for the mist; keep the horizon vague and oppressive.
- **Page 8 (the kneel)** — Arghun kneels from exhaustion, NOT submission. Draw it visibly different from the fearful kneeling at the gates in Ch.1.
- **Final splash (Page 11):** small figures, huge environment. The footprints behind them are important — they are the first mark anyone has made in the Wastes by choice.
- **Tone shift:** This chapter ends on something close to hope. Subtle, fragile, but real. Egris has his first companion.